



General ATC and Standards Policy

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VERSION 1.0

WARNING!

Information contained in this document is intended
for flight simulation purposes only.

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Purpose of Document

This document establishes the official ATC General Policy for VATSIM Sub-Saharan Africa (VATSSA). It sets out the standards, expectations, and procedures governing all rated controllers operating within the VATSSA division.

This policy has been developed to achieve the following objectives:

- Ensure high and consistent ATC standards are maintained throughout the VATSSA division.
- Provide controllers with a clear understanding of their responsibilities, conduct requirements, and currency obligations.
- Define the requirements and procedures for senior controller designations, including C3 and Overland FSS endorsements.
- Establish a structured framework for controller performance, oversight, and enforcement.
- Ensure that all controlling within VATSSA is conducted in a safe, professional, and procedurally correct manner.

VATSSA is committed to delivering a professional and consistent ATC environment for all network users within the region. This policy applies to all rated controllers operating within VATSSA airspace, including home controllers, visiting controllers, and those holding special endorsements.

1. Control Pages

1.1. Document Identification

Type	Policy
Revision	01/2026
Issue Date	
Effective Date	
Prepared By	Luke Van Zyl & Matthew Le Roux
Approved By	Wian Saptouw – VATSSA1 (Division Director)
Next Review Due	1st January 2027
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1.2. Revision Records

Version	Date	Description	Author
1.0	04/2026	Initial Policy Drafted	Luke Van Zyl & Matthew Le Roux

2. General Provisions

2.1. Applicability

This policy applies to all rated controllers operating within VATSSA airspace, regardless of their home division. It applies to home controllers, visiting controllers, and controllers holding endorsements. Controllers are responsible for familiarising themselves with the contents of this policy, as well as any other relevant VATSIM policies.

The content of this document reflects the essential modifications and regulations concerning the Global Controller Administration Policy (GCAP) as applicable within VATSSA.

2.2. Non-Compliance

Failure to comply with this policy may result in one or more disciplinary actions as outlined in Section 11. Any deviation from the requirements stated in this policy requires explicit written approval from the VATSSA ATC Training Manager.

2.3. Changes

This policy is subject to periodic review and amendment. Amendments may be made by the VATSSA ATC Training Department as required to address its clarity and effectiveness. Controllers will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, which will be published at vatssa.com.

3. Definitions

Term	Definition
Home Controller	A VATSIM member whose home division is VATSSA and who holds an approved controlling rating within the division.
Visiting Controller	A controller from another VATSIM division who has been granted permission to control within VATSSA airspace.
ATC Training Manager (VATSSA3)	The person responsible for overseeing the ATC Training department. Holds a Senior Instructor Rating (I3). Reports to the Division Director and Deputy Division Director.
Deputy ATC Training Manager (VATSSA8)	The person who reports to the ATC Training Manager and assists with ATC training and standards.
Controller Currency	The minimum controlling activity a controller must maintain to keep their approved rating active within VATSSA. Equates to 3 hours of controlling per quarter for standard positions.
Quarter	A three-month period used to measure controller currency: Jan–Mar, Apr–Jun, Jul–Sep, Oct–Dec.
Approved Position	A controlling position officially configured and published by VATSSA in AFV, the sector file, and on https://cc.vatssa.com/api/positions
Overland FSS	An Overland Flight Service Station position (AFRx_FSS) providing upper airspace coverage across Sub-Saharan Africa above FL245.
FSS Endorsement	A special endorsement issued by VATSSA authorising a controller to operate Overland FSS positions. Requires a C1 rating and additional training.
C3 Rating	An honorary designation awarded to controllers who have made exceptional contributions to the division. Not obtained through standard rating progression.
Strikes	Basic demerits are assigned to VATSSA members following misconduct or policy breaches.
docs.vatssa.com	Electronic Aeronautical Information Publication, used by controllers for procedural reference and preparation.
GCAP	Global Controller Administration Policy — the overarching VATSIM policy governing controller administration worldwide.
OTS	Operational Training Session — a supervised session used to assess a controller's readiness for an endorsement or rating.

4. Controller Conduct and Responsibilities

4.1. General Conduct

All controllers operating within VATSSA airspace must conduct themselves professionally at all times, including when connected to the network for any reason, and even when a communication or instruction is not directed at them specifically.

- Unprofessional behaviour, harassment, discrimination, or any conduct that brings the division or the network into disrepute will not be tolerated.
- Controllers must adhere to all applicable VATSIM regulations and VATSSA policies at all times.
- Controlling within VATSSA is a privilege, not a right. VATSSA reserves the right to withdraw approvals at its discretion.

Enforcement Note: *Failure to adhere to the expected conduct standards will result in strikes being assigned.*

4.2. Controller Responsibilities

Controllers are expected to take personal responsibility for the quality and professionalism of their controlling. This includes:

- Ensuring familiarity with current VATSSA procedures, phraseology, and published positions before connecting.
- Maintaining awareness of relevant docs.vatssa.com content for the positions being staffed.
- Actively monitoring the network and responding appropriately to traffic and other controllers.
- Providing a top-down service where appropriate and where no lower position is online.
- Keeping controlling software, sector files, and tools up to date as published by VATSSA.

4.3. Responsibility for Network Standards

- Maintaining high network standards is a shared responsibility between controllers, staff, and VATSSA.
- Controllers must appreciate that they represent VATSSA, and that substandard controlling impacts the division's reputation and the experience of all network users.
- Controllers are encouraged to constructively raise concerns about network standards through the appropriate VATSSA channels rather than taking matters into their own hands on the network.

5. Approved Positions and Frequencies

5.1. Approved Positions

Controllers operating within VATSSA airspace may only staff positions that are officially configured and published by the division. An approved position is one that is:

- Configured in Audio for VATSIM (AFV) with a designated frequency.
- Included in the current VATSSA sector file.
- Listed on the published position in the database (<https://cc.vatssa.com/api/positions>).

Procedural - must add now

The following variations of approved positions are also permitted where applicable:

- Approved mentoring positions, as designated by the ATC Training Department for use during supervised training sessions.
- Approved examination positions, as designated for use during Controller Practical Tests (CPTs).

5.2. Frequency Compliance

Controllers may only transmit on the frequencies designated for their approved position as published in the divisional configuration. The following are strictly prohibited:

- Use of non-published or self-assigned frequencies.
- Use of callsigns or position identifiers not appearing in the divisional configuration.
- Amending visibility or frequency settings within controlling software beyond those published by VATSSA.

5.3. Unauthorised Operations

- If a controller logs into a position without the required approvals, a VATSIM Supervisor will be contacted.
- Supervisors can access the current list of approved controllers on vatssa.com, and Division staff will follow up as necessary.
- The only recognised source for current controlling approvals within VATSSA is the listing on vatssa.com. No other source will be accepted as proof of approval to control.

6. Controller Currency

6.1. Currency Requirements

All controllers operating within VATSSA are required to maintain a minimum level of controlling activity to retain their divisional approvals. Currency is measured on a quarterly basis as follows:

Controller Type	Minimum Currency Requirement
Home Controllers	Minimum 3 hours of controlling per quarter within VATSSA.
Visiting Controllers	Minimum 3 hours of controlling per quarter within VATSSA.
Overland FSS Controllers (AFRx_FSS)	Minimum 1 hour per quarter on a VATSSA Overland FSS position.

The quarters used for currency measurement are as follows:

- Quarter 1: January – March
- Quarter 2: April – June
- Quarter 3: July – September
- Quarter 4: October – December

6.2. Consequences of Non-Compliance

- Failure to meet the above currency requirements may result in the withdrawal of controlling approvals within the Division as well as a referral to the VATSIM Supervisors Department and SSA membership
- The only recognised source for current controlling approvals is the listing on vatssa.com. No other source will be accepted as proof of approval to control.
- For Overland FSS controllers specifically, where currency is not maintained, an attempt will be made to contact the controller before removal from the approval list. However, VATSSA reserves the right to remove approvals without notice where warranted.

Enforcement Note: *Currency withdrawal does not constitute a disciplinary sanction and may be reinstated upon demonstration of the required competency. Repeated failure to maintain currency may, however, be considered alongside any broader assessment of a controller's engagement with the division.*

6.3. Currency Records

Controller currency is tracked through the VATSSA control centre system at cc.vatssa.com. Controllers are encouraged to monitor their own currency status through this platform. Any discrepancies should be reported to the Membership Manager (VATSSA4) or Tech Manager (VATSSA7) or the relevant staff member.

7. Controller Performance and Oversight

7.1. Performance Standards

All controllers operating within VATSSA are expected to maintain a consistent standard of operational performance. This includes:

- Applying correct phraseology in accordance with VATSSA Docs website and ICAO standards.
- Providing timely, accurate, and professional communications to all network users.
- Sequencing and separating traffic in a safe and efficient manner within their area of responsibility.
- Operating within the scope of their approved rating and any endorsements held.
- Demonstrating progressive improvement and a willingness to develop their skills over time.

7.2. Oversight and Observation

- Live controlling sessions may be observed by VATSSA ATC training staff at any time.
- Observations are conducted for quality assurance, standardisation, and network integrity purposes. They do not imply misconduct by the controller.
- Unannounced observations may occur from time to time to ensure consistency of standards across the division.
- Feedback arising from observations will be communicated to the controller through appropriate channels.

7.3. Feedback and Improvement

- Controllers are entitled to receive clear and constructive feedback following any formal observation.
- Controllers are encouraged to raise questions about procedures, standards, or feedback through the ATC Questions and Answers channel on the VATSSA Discord server.
- Controllers may not dispute operational decisions or feedback during live controlling sessions on the network.
- Concerns regarding training standards or feedback received must be raised through the appropriate VATSSA escalation channels.

8. Senior Controller Designation — C3

8.1. Overview

The C3 rating is an honorary senior controller designation within VATSSA. It is not obtained through standard VATSIM rating progression (training), but is instead awarded to controllers who have made exceptional and sustained contributions to the division and to the broader VATSIM network within the region.

The C3 designation recognises outstanding service, leadership, and commitment to the VATSSA community. It is awarded at the sole discretion of VATSSA1 and VATSSA3 and is not subject to application.

8.2. Eligibility Criteria

To be considered for a C3 designation, a controller must satisfy all of the following criteria:

- Hold a current C1 ATC rating with 100 hours as a minimum.
- Be a home controller within VATSSA and in good standing with the division.
- Have demonstrated sustained and exceptional contributions to the division, which may include but are not limited to: significant mentoring or training contributions, event organisation and delivery, technical development, or other divisional service.
- Maintain a clean disciplinary record within VATSSA and on the VATSIM network for a period of 3 years.
- Have been an active and engaged member of the VATSSA community for a significant period of time, 3 years.

***Note:** Meeting the above criteria does not guarantee the award of a C3 designation. The award is made entirely at the discretion of the Division Director (VATSSA1) in consultation with VATSSA and is reserved for truly exceptional cases.*

8.3. Award Process

- C3 designations are not open to application. Nominations may be brought to the attention of VATSSA1 by the ATC Training Manager.
- The final decision rests with the Division Director, who may consult with the Deputy Division Director prior to making a determination.
- All C3 awards will be communicated to the Division through official divisional channels at the time of the award.

8.4. Responsibilities of C3 Controllers

Controllers holding a C3 designation are expected to serve as role models within the community. This includes:

- Consistently demonstrating professional and exemplary controlling standards.
- Supporting the development of less experienced controllers where possible.
- Actively contributing to the division's mission and upholding its values.

9. Overland FSS Endorsement (UNDER REVIEW) NB!

9.1. Introduction

This section details the method of operations for Overland FSS controllers within VATSSA. It is important to note that this does not reflect real-world operations in any way, but instead provides a VATSIM method of operations for the provision of ATC services to pilots within the VATSSA region. These sectors are designed to ensure that ATC services can be provided to a greater number of VATSIM pilots across Sub-Saharan Africa.

9.2. FSS Airspace

There are three Overland FSS positions within the division, each covering upper airspace above FL245 across designated FIRs:

Callsign	Name	FIRs Covered (above FL245)
AFRC_FSS	Africa Central Control	FLFI, FNAN, FSSS, FWLL, FZZA, HKNA, HTDC, HUEC
AFRS_FSS	Africa South Control	FACA, FAJA, FBGR, FIMM, FMMM, FQBE, FVHF, FYWH
AFRW_FSS	Africa West Control	DGAC, DIII, DNKK, FCCC, GLRB, GOOO (incl. Oceanic), GVSC

9.3. Controller Qualifications

An Overland FSS Endorsement issued by VATSSA must be obtained prior to controlling any of the above positions. The criteria for obtaining such an endorsement are:

- The controller must hold an ATC rating of C1 or higher.
- The controller must have at least 25 hours of en route controlling prior to obtaining the endorsement, of which a minimum of 15 hours must be within VATSSA airspace.
- The controller must be an approved controller within VATSSA as a CTR controller.
- An Operational Training Session (OTS) may be requested prior to the endorsement being issued. A successful outcome is required.

Note: *The FSS endorsement is administered by the ATC Training Manager. Applications for the endorsement should be submitted via the appropriate channel on the VATSSA Discord server or through cc.vatssa.com.*

9.4. Controlling Practices

Within VATSSA, there are some procedural sectors, most notably Oceanic sectors, but also some overland sectors such as FQBE. For ease of providing services within VATSSA airspace, all airspace may be controlled by Overland FSS controllers as though the sectors were under radar control.

The following practices apply to Overland FSS operations:

- The use of direct routes within non-radar airspace should be avoided. Any radar headings utilised should be resolvable within a short space of time.
- Where an approach unit is online for an inbound aircraft, agreement should be sought with the approach controller to transfer traffic at FL240. The aircraft may be cleared to descend lower, but transfer of communications should occur at or around FL240.

- Departing aircraft should be climbing to FL240, with transfer of communications at or above FL180.
- Both voice and text communications are permitted throughout the FSS areas, as voice communication has been enabled throughout.

9.5. Radar Coverage and Visibility Settings

The sector files have been configured with visibility settings that do not interfere with other stations using the same frequencies as the FSS position. Controllers must not amend the visibility settings for these positions under any circumstances.

9.6. Transponder Operation

All aircraft under the control of Overland FSS positions must display a squawk relevant to that FSS position. Squawks assigned by ACCs should be amended, and all aircraft must be displaying a discrete FSS squawk at all times. This requirement exists due to the crossover of squawk assignments across VATSSA.

9.7. FSS Controller Currency

Overland FSS controllers are required to maintain a minimum of 1 hour of controlling per quarter on a VATSSA Overland FSS position. Where this currency is not maintained:

- An attempt will be made to contact the controller before removal from the FSS approval list.
- VATSSA reserves the right to remove FSS approvals where currency is not maintained, without prior notice.
- Removal from the FSS approval list does not affect a controller's standard controlling approvals, provided those currency requirements are met separately.

9.8. Sector Files

The latest sector file release dates are available on the VATSSA Discord server under the AFRX_FSS channel. Sector files for FSS positions can be downloaded by approved FSS controllers from vatssa.com.

Any issues or comments regarding the FSS positions should be sent to the ATC Training Department.

10. Controller Rights and Escalation

10.1. Controller Rights

- Controllers have the right to a respectful, professional, and constructive environment when operating within VATSSA.
- Controllers must be treated fairly and without discrimination in all divisional interactions.
- Controllers are entitled to clear and honest feedback following any formal observation or assessment.
- Controllers are encouraged to ask for clarification on procedures, standards, or divisional expectations through appropriate channels.

10.2. Escalation of Concerns

- Controllers may raise concerns through appropriate VATSSA channels, including the VATSSA Discord server or by contacting staff directly via the following emails: Feedback@vatssa.com / atc@vatssa.com.
- Concerns must be raised respectfully and in accordance with VATSSA policies.
- Controllers may not dispute operational decisions or network actions during live controlling sessions.
- Improper escalation or public disputes may result in disciplinary action.

11. Enforcement

11.1. Disciplinary Action

Failure to comply with this policy may result in one or more of the following:

- Strikes being assigned.
- Suspension of controlling approvals.
- Withdrawal of special endorsements (including FSS endorsement).
- Permanent withdrawal of controlling approvals within VATSSA and referral to the VATSIM Supervisors.

Enforcement Note: *Disciplinary action will be proportional to the severity and frequency of non-compliance. VATSSA reserves the right to act immediately where a situation demands it.*

12. Authority

- This policy is enforced by the VATSSA ATC Training Department and authorised by the Division Director.
- Decisions made under this policy are final unless otherwise stated by VATSSA procedures.

13. Review and Amendments

- This policy is subject to biannual review to ensure continued relevance and effectiveness, or when otherwise requested by the Division Director.
- Amendments to this policy may be made by the VATSSA ATC Training Department as required.
- Controllers will be expected to comply with the most current published version of this policy, published at policy.vatssa.com.